Philos
explor
develo
society

THE F
science
the accla
Appiah
tual curr
twentietl
formative
Burnett T
Simmel, a
the conce
interdeper
how their
evade the
tions of so
among the
merely an
through wh
lished socic

Appiah
work in bot
evolutionary
about the m
communitie
while unders
icance of the
temporary so
intertwines s
and philosop
our ideas abo
been, and con
logue with rel

Introduction

Communion

ON THE VERY IDEA OF RELIGION — THE POSSIBILITIES OF PLURALISM — FROM ANTHROPOTHEISMUS TO OPIUM — GOING THROUGH A PHASE — THE SCIENCE OF RELIGION — DEFINING TERMS — LOSING OUR "RELIGION" — THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF SOCIETY — NEGATIVE CAPABILITIES

"How's the water?" the old fish asks the young ones, in the modern wisdom tale. They respond with bafflement: "*What* water?" A medium of our existence, it might seem, rises to our consciousness only when it ebbs. That's one explanation for why the so-called classical sociologists, working mainly in the decade before and the decade after 1900, were preoccupied with religion—so preoccupied that the emerging science of society became at the same time a science of religion. In one familiar narrative, the decline of religion was implicated in a social crisis—the crisis called modernity, which intensified in the later decades of the nineteenth century—and sociology was created in order to explore it. Just as secularity made it possible to see religion as a distinct object of study, social dissolution made it possible to see society as one.

But this narrative is incomplete. It fails to explain why these scholars didn't take on religion as merely another phenomenon to be

elucidated, but instead decided that the social and religious—as structures, impulses, sentiments, practices—were inextricable categories, each unthinkable outside the other. As a matter of disciplinary history, the concepts of "society" and "religion" were conjoined twins. To be sure, each concept had previous lives outside the modern social sciences. Our social theorists drew on a considerable library concerning religions around the world. Yet this only brings out the difficulty that they had in defining what they were theorizing. In a secular theory of religion, the gods are secret captives of the societies that worship them, but our theorists themselves are captives, too, of their time and place. We cannot transcend our contexts.

In the chapters that follow, I will pursue a sort of conceptual genealogy through a detailed engagement with four thinkers as their thought took shape in the later decades of the nineteenth century. It's conventional to say that these four helped establish the modern social science of religion, but I want to explore what's hidden by that "of": it misleadingly suggests that religion was just one subject among others to which social science applied itself and belies the profound communion between the two. My aim, as will be evident, isn't to solve the "problem" of society or of religion; my principal interest is in excavating a fraught and consequential stratum of intellectual history. Still, attending to the early conceptual commensalism between the social sciences and religion may illuminate both.

ON THE VERY IDEA OF RELIGION

Because I want to remain alert to the fragility of our guiding concepts, it will be worth sketching, at the outset, how religions came to be seen as religions, long preceding the rise of modern theories about how we should think about them. Before the early modern era, for one thing, religion did not believe in religion. That is, what we would designate as religious traditions did not, in the main, conceive themselves as belonging to a class of different but functionally equivalent objects. To write about "religion" was, in this sense, to write as an enemy of religion. Inside my way of life, I know and can explain how the world works; only from outside can you assemble elements of that

worldview and call them a religion, to be placed in a vitrine alongside other religions.

In tracing the itinerary of the idea from, say, the Axial Age to the early modern era, our word "religion" can be an unreliable guide, in ways anticipated by Quentin Skinner's classic 1979 essay "The Idea of a Cultural Lexicon." "Religion," *religio*: among the Romans and early Christians, such words referred to rites and ceremonial observances, but didn't connote what we mean by religion. When Cicero, in one of his "Against Verres" orations of 70 BCE, said that the Sicilian governor's actions were "*contra omnes divinas atque humanas religiones*"—"against all divine and human *religiones*"—the word meant something like rules or strictures. Augustine of Hippo, accordingly, warns that the Latin term *religio* refers not only to the worship of God but also to "the observance of duties in human relationships." For Aquinas, in the thirteenth century, the word refers to monastic life. A fourteenth-century English use of "religions" refers to sects of Christianity.[1]

This book focuses on specific currents within intellectual life in Britain, France, and Germany in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries; the voices I'll take up will mainly be ones that were, in some measure, audible to my principals. But, taking a leaf from Skinner, we should avoid crude nominalism; the uncertain conceptual status of religion isn't just a point about a word, an exercise in logomachy. No term in the Bible truly corresponds to our term "religion." Islam, in premodern times, did not conceive itself as a religion, either. In his richly detailed study *Before Religion* (2013), Brent Nongbri observes that the word *islam*, which appears in nominal form only eight times in the Qur'an, is naturally taken to connote submission or obedience, not to name a creed; the participle *muslim*, in turn, designated one who submits. It appears that, in the seventh century, certain Jews could be members of the ummah, while some of Jesus's followers were themselves *muslimun*. Early members of the Christian church, for their part, understood Mohammedans not as followers of anything like a religion but as heretics, pagans, or idolaters.[2]

It was in the seventeenth century that the term, as it circulated in the Latin world of European intellection, came securely to acquire its modern, comparative sense: you see it in the title of Hugo Grotius's *De*

veritate religionis Christianae (1627). This emerging conception—the term is pretty much the same in all the major European tongues—was fueled by the fracturing represented by the Reformation (Christian forms of worship were diverse, but it had still been possible to imagine a unified Christendom under submission to a universal Church). It was fueled, too, by new scholarship about the ancient world, and by the imperial conquests of the New World, along with increased engagement with yet other parts of the globe.

The convergence of these forces is emblematized in a much-discussed dream of Baruch Spinoza's. Writing to a friend in 1664—eight years after his excommunication for heresy—Spinoza wrote of a vision he'd had of "a certain black and scabby Brazilian." Even after he awoke, the image kept reappearing, just as vividly, and faded only gradually. Scholars recall that, in the previous decade, a slave rebellion in Pernambuco, then a Dutch-controlled region of Brazil, had returned it to Portuguese hands.[3] Nobody was more aware of the plurality of belief than the era's most consequential heretic, someone whose theory of God, as a substance coterminous with all existence, seemingly made him fit for no religion at all. In the meantime, scholars have identified a shift from an essential Catholic association of religion with ritual to a more Protestant version that foregrounds a state of mind, an attitude of pious reverence or adoration. "Faith," increasingly, can be used as a synonym.[4] To this day, we tend to refer to practicing Catholics and believing Protestants.

THE POSSIBILITIES OF PLURALISM

It will be helpful, at this point, to give a swift, as-I-stand-on-one-foot overview of how religion was theorized from the mid-eighteenth-century to the early decades of the nineteenth century. For here we'll find intellectual touchstones that the principals of this book took for granted as part of a common inheritance. Everyone in their scholarly circles was at least ambiently aware of them.

The concept of religion gained sharper contours during the Enlightenment, because it was a focus of intent scholarly attention—attention that, as you would expect, was not always reverent. David Hume's *The*

Natural History of Religion (1757) told readers that polytheism and idolatry characterized religion in its most ancient form, one that was ubiquitous in ancient times and still held by the savage peoples of Asia, Africa, and America. How does monotheism arise? Worshippers promote one deity over the others, perhaps as "their peculiar patron, or as the general sovereign of heaven," and, to gain his favor, extravagant flattery is directed toward him, eventually arriving at the ascription of infinite power and presence. Yet even when a supreme deity has been erected, Hume says, there's a tendency to lift up subordinates to divine status, as the Catholic Church had done with the Virgin Mary and various saints.[5] The naturalistic perspective was disturbing to many: to explain the rise of credal beliefs while failing to accord a causal role to their reality was (clerics feared) to explain religion *away*.

Religion had Enlightenment allies, too. Gotthold Ephraim Lessing, the exemplary religious rationalist of the age, had a strategy for dealing with the plurality of religious practices and the rise of materialist explanation. There's an "inner truth" within us, he proposed, that is the engine of various religious modalities and that will ultimately guide mankind to an "eternal gospel" not yet within our reach.[6] On this view, a comparative study of religions need not be a study in error; it could be a study in complementary strivings toward a larger truth not yet fully revealed. But even these benevolent approaches might erode the genuine power of faith. The twentieth-century scholar (and Presbyterian minister) Wilfred Cantwell Smith saw in them the replacement of historical communities of belief with the notion of a generic religion; it was a process in which—as another scholarly Smith, Jonathan Z. Smith, writes—religion was "domesticated" and "transformed from pathos to ethos."[7]

From this perspective, religion's most sophisticated and influential defenders in the decades that followed were unwitting fifth columnists of secularity. Consider Friedrich Schleiermacher, who was a housemate, in the late 1790s, of the arch-Romantic Friedrich Schlegel (later a son-in-law of Moses Mendelssohn's), and who, with Schlegel's encouragement, published a 1799 volume titled *On Religion: Speeches to Its Cultured Despisers*. For Schleiermacher, "religion" encompasses monotheisms and polytheisms, but was, at its essence, a realm of

"intuition and feeling."[8] That feeling—the essence of religion, he later suggested—could be described more specifically: it was "the feeling of absolute dependence."[9] Influenced by Johann Gottfried von Herder, he was a pluralist of a sort: "just as nothing is more irreligious than to demand uniformity in humanity generally, so nothing is more unchristian than to seek uniformity in religion." In his second speech, he admits that defining religion is a daunting task. But in the end, religion's shared goal is "to love the world spirit and joyfully observe its work." For him, accordingly, every faith tradition, including "polytheistic Egypt," contained an intuition or longing for the one in the all.[10] Religion was, in contemporary terms, akin to an application programming interface with the divine; it's just that some APIs were fitter, or closer to the truth, than others. This was someone who hoped to have his pathos and ethos, too.

FROM ANTHROPOTHEISMUS TO OPIUM

If God wasn't in the details, secular scholars might now take the holy writ itself as a historical document. David Strauss's *Life of Jesus Critically Examined* (1835–1836) did just this. Strauss highlighted contradictions and inconsistencies in the tales of the New Testament and argued that these accounts had to be understood as symbolic or mythological renderings that expressed the early Christian community's faith in Jesus, with the various texts reflecting the particular theological agendas of their respective authors and communities. But it was Ludwig Feuerbach who posed the greater test of faith. He had grown up in a devoutly Lutheran family, studied theology at Heidelberg, and then transferred to the University of Berlin. Schleiermacher was teaching there, but Feuerbach switched his course of study to philosophy, attending Hegel's lectures quite religiously. Reading Strauss contributed to his reconsideration of his hero. In *The Essence of Christianity* (1841), Feuerbach ventures something like an anthropology of religion, or what he termed "Anthropotheismus"; human beings can see only what they're equipped to see, and their God is a projection of their vision. (He was religiously too heterodox for an academic career, but his wife had inherited a share of a porcelain factory, and he was able to

live as an independent scholar.) Certain Hegelian influences are legible here: a certain conception of self-consciousness and self-alienation, a certain conception of historical development, a certain role for emanation. But for Hegel, our knowledge of God was part of an unfolding process of self-realization—with religion, divided into stages, being itself a stage, as an imperfect representation of the Absolute Spirit.[11] For Feuerbach, God is, decidedly, a purely human creation.

What was religion? It was a question Feuerbach took up with a certain fervor:

> Religion is the relation of man to his own nature,—therein lies its truth and its power of moral amelioration;—but to his nature not recognised as his own, but regarded as another nature, separate, nay, contradistinguished from his own: herein lies its untruth, its limitation, its contradiction to reason and morality; herein lies the noxious source of religious fanaticism, the chief metaphysical principle of human sacrifices, in a word, the *prima materia* of all the atrocities, all the horrible scenes, in the tragedy of religious history.

Where Schleiermacher supposed that the more developed forms of religion brought us closer to the divine, Feuerbach supposed that the less developed forms of religion bring us closer to the truth about human creeds: "the nearer religion stands to its origin, the truer, the more genuine it is, the less is its true nature disguised; that is to say, in the origin of religion there is no qualitative or essential distinction whatever between God and man. And the religious man is not shocked at this identification; for his understanding, is still in harmony with his religion."[12] (I've been quoting George Eliot's careful translation.) After Feuerbach, religion—at least for a formidable educated cadre—became firmly situated as a *something*, not an everything. Studying it, we could learn about human nature and about human relations.

Perhaps we would learn nothing good. Karl Marx was an attentive and enthusiastic reader of Feuerbach—he tried to commission a piece from him for his planned French and German *Jahrbücher*—even though, famously, he thought Feuerbach's analysis fell short in critical ways. It did so because it was insufficiently social. "Feuerbach dissolves

the religious essence into the human essence. But the human essence is not an abstraction inherent in each particular individual," Marx writes in his 1845 "Theses on Feuerbach." "In its reality it is the ensemble of social relationships." And so Feuerbach "does not see that the 'religious sentiment' is itself a social product, and that the abstract individual he analyses belongs to a specific form of society."[13]

For Marx, convinced by the mid-1840s that "the criticism of religion has been essentially completed," the struggle against religion was a staging ground for a struggle against a world to which religion had given a "spiritual aroma." Religion may have been a phantasm, but it arose from the cruelty of actual subjugation: "Religious suffering is both the expression of real suffering and a protest against real suffering. Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the soul of a heartless world, and it is also the soul of soulless conditions. It is the opium of the people." He goes on to write that the protest against real suffering must be carried out through the scrutiny of religion: "The criticism of religion is, therefore, the germ of the criticism of that vale of tears whose halo is religion."[14] In this account, Hegel's Absolute Spirit has been inverted and replaced with the materiality of subjugation; religion has been afforded little autonomy beyond that afforded what he mischievously terms "the halo," the *Heiligenschein*. Marx is writing with the clarity of combat. But also with the fixed view of combat: this is religion in the singular, uninflected and undifferentiated.

GOING THROUGH A PHASE

In France, August Comte, the man who, perhaps prematurely, coined the term "sociology" (he would have preferred "social physics," but that had a prior claimant, the formidable Belgian statistician Adolphe Quetelet), had already been approaching the question of religion through an elaborate intellectual edifice. Comte's six-volume *Course of Positive Philosophy*, which assembled a series of texts largely written in the 1830s—then abridged and "freely" translated into English by the intrepid Harriet Martineau in 1853—proposed that the intellectual development of our species began with what he termed a theological stage, in which phenomena were explained as the outcome of magic and

supernatural entities. (The stage had the substages that led from fetishism to polytheism to monotheism.) Our development then advanced to a metaphysical stage, which supplanted such spiritual entities with abstractions such as essences, vital principles, and teleology, as well as a consideration of human tendencies. The third stage was the positive, scientific one, given over to systematic forms of inquiry—measurement, observation, statistical evidence, verification—that allowed us to establish the causal laws governing natural phenomena. True science confined itself to "positive facts"—observation-derived data, which, unlike metaphysical speculation, could be positively affirmed. (For Marx, this was the sin of idealism: by focusing on ideas, it scanted the material and historical conditions that shape societies.)

What's striking is that Comte, in his later years, sought to replicate and reform religion in the image of science, devising a Religion of Humanity—complete with a priesthood, prayers, and rituals—devoted to furtherance of altruism and the veneration of humankind. (You can still find positivist Chapels of Humanity in France and Brazil.) Even admirers found this a bit much. In a book on Comte and positivism, John Stuart Mill found "something ineffably ludicrous" in Comte's instruction that his devotional practices be engaged in three times each day for a two-hour period.[15] Thomas Huxley acidly called the Religion of Humanity "Catholicism minus Christianity."[16]

Still, Comte's vision of humanity's movement through progressive phases of understanding was catalyzing for many intellectuals, not least in Great Britain. Among them was Comte's English translator, Harriet Martineau, who began her career as a contributor to a Unitarian monthly. In her *Society in America*, from 1837, she deplored the ascetic form of Christianity she found widespread in the United States (she thought it could not endure, "it is so destitute of all reason") and worried about the way American women had taken to religion, which testified, in part, "to the vacuity which must exist when such a mistake is fallen into." But it was the ascetic strain that disturbed her, not the true spirit of religion: "It brings religion down to be ceremonial, constrained, anxious, and altogether divested of its free, generous, and joyous character." At this point, she thought that the "spirit of Humanity" was the "very sanctum of religion."[17]

In the preface to Martineau's 1853 edition of Comte and in a treatise in the form of a correspondence with Henry Atkinson, *Letters on the Laws of Man's Nature and Development* (1853), she elaborated a worldview in which the laws of the universe would be uncovered through scientific inquiry rather than religious doctrine. And yet she worried about the dangers posed by the discarding of religion. "I believe that no one questions that a very large proportion of our people are now so adrift," she wrote in that preface, alert to a decline in ecclesiastical authority. Fortunately, Comte's system of belief, with its radiant vision of progress, represented "the greatest single effort that has been made to obviate this kind of danger."[18]

THE SCIENCE OF RELIGION

The disengagement from formal religion among intellectuals in the industrializing West—a disengagement that people like Martineau represented and helped spread—had consequences for the way they thought about religions elsewhere. The concept of "world religions," Tomoko Masuzawa observes, took root at a time when European scholars saw nonmodern people elsewhere in the world as in the grips of religion in a way that these scholars were not. At the same time, these religions, to be religions, had to be akin to Christianity: they were vast metaphysical systems interwoven with all aspects of society; they had a sacred scripture of some sort; they had a God or gods. As she observes, the framework required that scholars reprocess a great deal of the cultural and political activities they observed among foreigners.[19] This was a form of pluralism on the universalist terms of the European pluralists.

In the nineteenth-century science of religion, or *Religionswissenschaft*, a discipline that emerged in the 1870s, Buddhism proved a fascinating test case. First, scholars had to deem a set of diverse practices in South, Central, Southeast, and East Asia to be variants of a single thing.[20] An 1844 British study focused on a set of Sanskrit documents and Gautama Buddha as its originary figure; an early "pure" form was to be excavated and distinguished from later corrupted forms. But once the entity had been identified, or confected, the issue of whether

it counted as a religion had to be resolved. The Oxford professor of Sanskrit, Sir Monier Monier-Williams, in an 1889 study, insisted it did not: "Christianity is a religion, whereas Buddhism, at least in its earliest and truest form, is no religion at all, but a mere system of morality and philosophy founded on a pessimistic theory of life." At the same time, it was configured on the analogy of religion: there was, as Masuzawa notes, the "extraordinary yet historically genuine person as the founder and initiator of the tradition," and there was some canonical set of ancient texts.[21] (Scripture could be ascribed to Shintoism and Hinduism, even if a founder couldn't be identified.) And soon it was broadly accepted as a religion, even a *Weltreligion*, which is to say, not just a religion in the world but a religion of the world, with universal—transnational, transtemporal—tendencies.

European theorists could have found their categories challenged closer to home. When did Judaism become a religion? Leora Batnitzky, in a fascinating book on the topic, shows that it functioned, in medieval times, as creed, culture, and nationality at once and people weren't in the habit of seeing these things as distinct. She argues that it was, more than anyone, Moses Mendelssohn (Friedrich Schlegel's father-in-law) who invented the idea that Judaism was a religion, assimilating it to a German Protestant conception that, she notes, Judaism didn't quite fit. Lutheranism, Calvinism, Catholicism: these were organized faith practices that appeared to be playing roughly the same role, that could be conceived as separable from the state, even from the emerging notion of a nation-state. But *Judentum*—a word that could mean Jewry, Jewishness, or Judaism—remained tied to ideas of descent and of a nationhood of its own.[22] An ex-Jew, in the sense of one who had given up traditional beliefs or practices, remained a kind of Jew.

DEFINING TERMS

Meanwhile, efforts to define religion persisted with a proselytic zeal, in part because no contender gained wide acceptance. "What, in truth, are the conditions necessary to constitute a religion?" John Stuart Mill asked in his book on Comte. "There must be a creed, or conviction, claiming authority over the whole of human life; a belief, or set of

beliefs, deliberately adopted, respecting human destiny and duty, to which the believer inwardly acknowledges that all his actions ought to be subordinate. Moreover, there must be a sentiment connected with this creed, or capable of being invoked by it, sufficiently powerful to give it in fact, the authority over human conduct to which it lays claim in theory." Notice the triune nature of the definition, in which sentiment connected beliefs and actions. Herbert Spencer, writing in 1867, went smaller: what religions all had in common was "the tacit conviction that the existence of the world with all it contains and all which surrounds it, is a mystery ever pressing for interpretation."[23]

A few years later, Edward B. Tylor, as we'll see, proposed a "belief in Spiritual Beings" as the minimum definition that connected religions across the historical stages of development. His ally and sparring partner Max Müller, in an 1873 book, offered a definition that would not have been inhospitable to Lessing and Schleiermacher: religion "is a mental faculty" that, "independent of, nay in spite of sense and reason, enables man to apprehend the Infinite under different names and under varying guises."[24] In an alternative formulation, friendly to the nonbeliever, religion "consists in the perception of the infinite under such manifestations as are able to influence the moral character of man."[25] In *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature* (1902), William James (who decided that Buddhism was, strictly, atheistic) expressed impatience with "verbal" disputation, but then offered an account consistent with older Protestant, state-of-mind approaches: "*the feelings, acts and experiences of individual men in their solitude, so far as they apprehend themselves to stand in relation to whatever they may consider the divine*." Evidently worried that his formulation had begged too many questions, he then took up another angle: "the life of religion," taken in the broadest terms, "consists of the belief that there is an unseen order, and our supreme good lies in harmoniously adjusting ourselves thereto."[26] In *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (1912), Émile Durkheim—who sought to include Buddhism, where spirits or gods didn't necessarily play a role—proposed a definition that had the breadth of Mill's but with a social valence: "A religion is a unifying system of beliefs and of practices in relation to sacred things—that is, things kept apart, forbidden—beliefs and

practices that unite all those who adhere to them into one moral community, called the Church."[27]

That same year, two other books notably acknowledged the difficulty of the definitional enterprise. In *Themis: A Study of the Social Origins of Greek Religion*, the classical scholar and linguist Jane Ellen Harrison announced, "we shall at the outset attempt no definition of the term religion, but we shall collect the facts that admittedly are religious and see from what human activities they appear to have sprung." Toward the end, she advised, "A definition however illuminating always desiccates its object."[28] In *A Psychological Study of Religion: Its Origin, Function, and Future*, James H. Leuba, a psychology professor at Bryn Mawr, denied that religion could be characterized by any particular emotion or purpose, and eschewed the "little formulae called definitions of religion," but he allowed that its end was to maintain and perfect life, and that it was a functional part of the "struggle for life."[29] In an appendix, he anthologized dozens of proposed definitions, dividing them into intellectualistic, affectivistic, and voluntaristic.

Few were more cautious than Max Weber and Georg Simmel. At the opening of a work on religion, Weber declared, "To define 'religion,' to say what it *is*, is not possible at the start"; he did not promise it would be possible at the end, either. Simmel, sounding like a bruised veteran, urged a retreat from the field of definitional combat: "No light will ever be cast in the sibyllic twilight that, for us, surrounds the origin and nature of religion as long as we insist on approaching it as a single problem requiring only a single word for its solution. Thus far no one has been able to offer a definition of religion that is both precise and sufficiently comprehensive. No one has been able to grasp its ultimate essence, shared by the religions of Christians and of South Sea islanders, of Buddha and Vitzliputzli."[30]

LOSING OUR "RELIGION"

Ensuing generations have not caught Simmel out. Functionalist definitions—many developed in the wake of A. R. Radcliffe-Brown and Bronisław Malinowski, and invariably drawing on Durkheim—typically wave aside the specific requirement of supernatural or

superhuman entities. They attended to what religion did: the way it supported social cohesion and control, offered psychological support (especially in the face of crises, including death), marked rites of passage, legitimized social institutions, and so on. For critics, though, waiving that requirement was a fatal flaw: whatever functionalism explained, they thought, it did not explain religion. Religions weren't always sources of social stability; sometimes they were the opposite. Conversely, cultural systems not obviously religious in nature appeared to provide these functions, too. Functionalism was even suspected of tautology, of defining religion by functions that are then used to explain the existence of religion. And then functionalism had little to say about what religion meant to its practitioners.

The anthropologist Melford Spiro, in a paper from 1966 that socialized Tylor's stipulation, decided that religion was "an institution consisting of culturally patterned interaction with culturally postulated superhuman beings."[31] It was another definition published that year, though, that generated a notably vast literature, concurring or contesting. In the essay "Religion as a Cultural System," the anthropologist Clifford Geertz stipulated that religion was "(1) a system of symbols which acts to (2) establish powerful, pervasive, and long-lasting moods and motivations in men by (3) formulating conceptions of a general order of existence and (4) clothing these conceptions with such an aura of factuality that (5) the moods and motivations seem uniquely realistic."[32] An immediate question that arose was whether a formula that included Confucianism and Buddhism and Stoicism could exclude Marxism, forms of nationalism, and so forth. A deeper question, to which I'll return, had to do with the privileged status of the symbolic.

Symbolism has, in the event, had a broad constituency. For the sociologist Robert N. Bellah, too, symbolism was key: "Religion is a set of symbolic forms and acts which relate man to the ultimate condition of his existence."[33] Critics worry that symbolism is too powerful a solvent, dissolving disparate phenomena into a slurry of vague significance. And because, in these models, the status of entities *as* symbols may not be apparent to those who use them, symbolists must continually deny that people quite mean what they say.

Other approaches have arrived, with helpful mnemonics. They may distinguish religion through four C's, if not necessarily the same C's. Creed, cultus, code, and community are the characteristic features, in one version. In another version, we're offered "counterintuition (supernatural agents), commitment (costly sacrifice), compassion (relief from existential anxieties), and communion (emotion-arousing ritual)"—taken to be "cultural manipulations of psychological adaptations."[34] Ninian Smart sought to demarcate religion through what he took to be its seven dimensions (ritual, experiential, mythological, doctrinal, ethical, institutional, and material). All are no doubt useful angles of approach, whether or not the sum of the angles completes a definitional circle.

Evolutionary accounts have evolved their own definitions. Robin Dunbar says that "a minimalist definition of religion might be belief in some kind of transcendental world (that may or may not coincide with our observable physical world) inhabited by spirit beings or forces (that may or may not take an interest in and influence the physical world in which we live)." The philosopher Daniel Dennett, whose work has an evolutionary bent, carefully words his definition of religions as "social systems whose participants avow belief in a supernatural agent or agents whose approval is to be sought."[35] One thinks of the Mumbai gentleman Rohinton Mistry writes about in *Such a Long Journey*, who, all too plausibly, spends his days railing against the Almighty.[36] And doxastic accounts, focused on belief or even the avowal of belief, are mistrusted by those who regard them as artifacts of the Protestant paradigm, and who consider institutions and practices, not beliefs (or simple belief avowals), to be central in many religious traditions.

The Millian move of connecting behavior and belief remains available. One influential sociologist of religion, Martin Riesebrodt, argues that " 'religion as such' isn't an empirically accessible object," but that "religion" can and should be retained, and proposes to define it as a "complex of practices that are based on the premise of the existence of superhuman powers, whether personal or impersonal, that are generally invisible."[37] ("Religiousness," the subjective enlistment of religion, figures large in his account.) But for many scholars, the urgent challenge is to wrest religion from paradigms that are in some combination Christian, or Western, or modern.

Secularity, in the anthropologist and cultural theorist Talal Asad's widely discussed account, is a specific artifact of Western modernity, responsive to certain ideological interests, as is the simultaneous effort to delimit a specific domain as religious. Asad urges us to see religion through an archeology of its shifting conceptions, and to resituate it as something embodied in practices, such as rituals, gestures, and forms of worship, that are not merely symbolic expressions of inner states, but are themselves constitutive of religious experience and meaning. That requires keeping in mind the way that religious practices and discourses are shaped by the material and institutional conditions in which they occur, such as the built environment, economic relations, and political structures. Yet religion—a concept Asad is intent on saving—can sometimes seem merely epiphenomenal in this account, more a product of political and social forces than a shaper of them. Critics have wondered, too, how we were to know that all these very different things, shaped by local forces and features, were all examples of the same thing.[38]

In the past decades, we've had the "family resemblance" and polythetic approaches (I'll discuss these in Chapter 5) that urge us to take the notion of religion as we see it, and give up on any specific list of necessary and sufficient conditions. For certain scholars, though, the religion concept is beyond redemption. Wilfred Cantwell Smith thought that talk of religion conflated too many things not to cause mischief. He considered it Eurocentric, conducive of bigotry, and—of critical importance to him—hostile to piety. "Neither religion in general nor any of the religions," he argued in his classic *The Meaning and End of Religion* (1962), "is in itself an intelligible entity, a valid object of inquiry or of concern either for the scholar or for the man of faith."[39] Why not speak of faith and of cumulative traditions, and jettison religion?

The stakes for other eliminativists are more political. For one recent critic, treating religion as a sui generis object isolates people from their sociopolitical contexts and treats them "not as social, economic, and political beings with certain basic material needs and relations but as essentially believers of creeds."[40] Another worries that religion not only fails to demarcate any cross-culturally coherent category, but also belongs to a broader process of "western imperialism, colonialism, and

neocolonialism."[41] The theologian Gordon Lynch, hoping to reform our notions of the sacred, has recently worried that the concept of religion, far from a neutral cross-cultural category, picks out "the kinds of social institution and subjectivity appropriate to modern, liberal, and Enlightened societies," in ways implicated in cultural projects such as colonial domination. He wonders whether the study of religion might be reconceived as "the study of the operations of the discourse of 'religion' in academic thought and other arenas of social life"; or at least "as the study of whatever is constructed as 'religion' in a particular context."[42] Save religion, he proposes, by losing "religion," or at least scare-quoting it into submission.

Other scholars have been scouting for a replacement concept. Daniel Dubuisson, who considers "religion" a nineteenth-century Western product imposed on the anthropology of the non-Western world, suggests, as an alternative, the concept of a "cosmographic formation"—which could be taken as not so much an alternative to "religion" as a superior definition of it. Critics have been unmoved. Riesebrodt prophesied, mordantly, that cosmographic formations and the like can be shown to "have also been 'constructed' through historically specific discourses," and revealed as "instruments in the linguistic battle between classes or cultures."[43]

Shall we content ourselves with talk of religion buffered by a strong sense of its artifactual nature? Jonathan Z. Smith, the celebrated historian of religions, once surveyed four comparative modes of religious inquiry—the ethnographic, the encyclopedic, the morphological, and the evolutionary—and threw up his hands with genial ecumenicism. "Religion is solely the creation of the scholar's study," he wrote, with "no independent existence apart from the academy." But this wasn't the counsel of defeatism. As he later elaborated, the term was created for scholarly purposes and was for scholars to define. "It is a second-order generic concept that plays the same role in establishing a disciplinary horizon that a concept such as 'language' plays in linguistics or 'culture' plays in anthropology. There can be no disciplined study of religion without such a horizon."[44]

Let me end my disciplinary survey here. Inasmuch as religion is the creation of the scholar's study, the principals I will discuss in the

chapters ahead weren't merely theorists of religions but creators of "religion." As I noted at the start, society, as a subject of inquiry, emerged from the secular study of something called religion, and vice versa. By the same token, "society" is equally the creation of a scholar's study. Indeed, the extent to which contemporary social theory continues to be shadowed by the early explorations of Durkheim, Simmel, and Weber, our classical sociologists, is remarkable. When we think about society, we still use their lenses. And the concept of religion was used to grind those lenses.

THE SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF SOCIETY

When did our concept of "society" emerge? What we're looking for is not the "body" model you find in some medieval discourse (the king is the head, the realm the body); nor merely taxonomical (wherever it is that laws and institutions do their work); nor an abstraction that possesses no agency or *all* the agency; nor simply a group of co-located individuals. As an object of study, we can't quite see it in Hobbes and Locke: they spoke of society, even civil society, of the common good and the private good; and yet their social contracts were an undertaking of individuals. We can't quite see it in Rousseau's social-contract model, either, where we're regularly asked to veer between individuals and some abstract and unitary collective. Nor do we quite find it in Diderot or Helvetius.

Something closer to our notion of society is presaged by the luminaries of the Scottish Enlightenment, notably Adam Ferguson, James Dunbar, John Millar, David Hume, Francis Hutcheson, and Adam Smith. In their writing, society is certainly more than a group of co-located individuals. In Ferguson's *Essay on the History of Civil Society*, it was an assemblage that evolved according to internal forces, shaped by the division of labor, property relations, and so on. Ferguson insisted, too, on the group as a unit of analysis: "Mankind are to be taken in groupes, as they have always subsisted. The history of the individual is but a detail of the sentiments and the thoughts he has entertained in the view of his species: and every experiment relative to this subject should be made with entire societies, not with single men." Smith,

famously, compared society to a mirror that allows the human creature to comprehend what he is. Dunbar deemed society "the free and legitimate offspring of the human heart"; Hutcheson was sure that society was "enjoined by the Law of Nature." Hume was convinced that "man, born in a family, is compelled to maintain society from necessity, from natural inclination, and from habit."[45]

Yet "society," for our Scotsmen, is an essentially static entity. It's the cumulative result of individual action shaped by human nature and historical circumstance, and set to proceed through orderly stages. What we don't find is anything like an analysis of group processes and interactive dynamics; we don't have social structures with a logic and causal powers separate from individual agency.

Thinking about "the social" gained a particular charge in the first half of the nineteenth century. To paint with a broad brush, the French Revolution had shown the power of social forces to shape history, while the Industrial Revolution was creating new forms of social interdependence and conflict. And though it's simplistic to see the models of society that were promulgated in the penumbra of revolution as reactive or reactionary, some of them, in some part, clearly were so.

Comte, an enemy of Enlightenment individualism, supposed society to be bound by natural-law-like regularities, such that it could be studied much as we studied the natural world, which is why he was so drawn to "social physics." Society was greater than the sum of its parts, but precisely the way an organism is; a unified whole, it evolved in a quasi-biological and determinate way. With respect to the social upheavals of his day, it could be said that Comte thought he had proposed a cure—a protocol for a radiantly peaceable mode of coexistence. Robert Nisbet, the sociologist and historian of sociology, was onto something when he provocatively suggested that Comte's was a medievalist conception of society: "Into its veins Comte pumped the blood of Positivism, replacing Catholicism, but he leaves us in no doubt of his admiration of the structure of medieval society or of his desire to restore its essence."[46] Normatively and empirically, Comtean society was idealized out of recognition.

In the meantime, the "social question"—with urbanization, too often, leading to pauperization—posed the specter of fragmentation

and instability. Society as a cohesive force becomes salient when cohesion falters. What about Karl Marx's model of society, then? His model, while stadial, was certainly not static. In the century's most influential critique of bourgeois society, he had identified, in the capitalist mode of production, a fundamental antagonism between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat that could be resolved only through revolution. Society was not simply an aggregate of individuals, but a complex totality structured by historically specific relations of production, that is, class relations. He grants that individuals constitute one another—and that this was true even in our early, herd-like social consciousness, when society was agonistic and riven by contradictions, not functionally integrated or equilibrating. "It is not the consciousness of men that specifies their being, but their social being that specifies their consciousness," Marx wrote.[47]

At the same time, his view was still very much a nineteenth-century one, wedded to unabashed social evolutionism and historical determinism, with crisply demarcated developmental stages. (Among the classical sociologists I focus on, you'll find *abashed* social evolutionism.) More than that, Marx's materialism mirrors the idealism it opposes, abstracting away from cultural particularity to expose universal laws of historical progression. Social superstructures—legal systems, politics, culture, morality, metaphysics, corresponding to "definite forms of social consciousness"—emanate from the economic base. The social, in this model, is demoted to bondsman, captive to the dictates of the economic. In the mode of an old-school natural scientist, too, Marx's language is not of tendency but of necessity (even as the necessitarian language has, itself, a theological resonance). Finally, the soteriological vision of a stateless and classless communist society—in which the division of labor and attendant forms of differentiation were erased, along with all local loyalties, was scarcely recognizable as a human society at all. The sociologist Donald MacRae declared, understandably, that Marx "neither was—nor in an important sense intended to be—a sociologist."[48] The canons of disciplinary history rule out such a peremptory judgment. But his theories do sideline the forms of social inquiry that our principals wanted to explore.

Marx's near-contemporary Herbert Spencer—who, in writing of sociology, took up Comte's coinage, though not his political program—

was intent on severing sociology from socialism. But his depictions of society do not easily slot into the modern program, either. His writings variously emphasized society as a unity, society as a system of organs, and society as an assemblage of atomistic individuals. It must be said that another way in which Spencer was not a modern sociologist was the extent to which he was committed to racial hierarchy, envisaging serried ranks of humanity marked by differences in capacity. He even bruited a notion of progress as propelled, in part, by ongoing race war, "a continuous over-running of the less powerful or less adapted by the more powerful or more adapted, a driving of inferior varieties into undesirable habitats, and, occasionally, an extermination of inferior varieties."[49]

Still, the "social turn" of the nineteenth century, it should be clear, was under way before our pioneers of sociology started their work. Debates involving Young Hegelians other than Marx contributed; so, as we'll see, did the *Völkerpsychologie* of Moritz Lazarus and Heymann Steinthal and then of Wilhelm Wundt, as well as the psychological "ethnology" of Theodor Waitz—to begin a long list. But in the writings of our later sociologists, the salience of the social coalesced. In Weber's metaphor, ideas can create worldviews that, like a railroad switchman, reroute collective trains of thought—especially when social, economic, and cultural conditions are aligned.

Sociology was a product of an age that experienced fracture, social dissolution, and, yes, anomie, and that was marked by much fretting about whether these developments were the cause or consequences of the erosion of religion. Simmel rightly mocked the temptation to think that problems exist for the sake of being solved. But because modern sociology arose amid not only a crisis in religion but also a crisis in society, its first steps were to devise theories about what each thing was. These overlapping conceptions of society—as a dynamic complement of representations, norms, sentiments, constraints, ideals, authority, and so on—then emerged as a field of study and as a mode of explanation.

There were other terms in contention: for Tylor, "culture or civilization" was the thing to be studied. But "society" had sticking power. When Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher, in a 1987 interview, said

"there is no such thing as society," she was arguing with exactly this range of conceptions.[50] So it's telling that her next sentence started to walk back the provocation: "There is a living tapestry of men and women and people and the beauty of that tapestry and the quality of our lives will depend upon how much each of us is prepared to take responsibility for ourselves and each of us prepared to turn round and help by our own efforts those who are unfortunate." (With Penelope-like determination, policy mavens are always trying to weave and unweave that living tapestry.) Society, the sociologists saw, was exactly what put us in a position to try to understand entities like society; it was an unappeasable god that had created us, could support us, would outlive us, and, though it would always surpass our mortal efforts to theorize it, might reward our efforts to do so.

NEGATIVE CAPABILITIES

I've suggested that religion becomes an object of study once we can conceive a space away from it, just as social dissolution encourages scholars to study the forces of social cohesion and refine their conceptions of society. In Edward Burnett Tylor, Émile Durkheim, Georg Simmel, and Max Weber, we see a larger disciplinary toolkit emerging from their years of wrestling with religion. Durkheim, Simmel, and Weber are conventionally regarded as among the disciplinary architects of sociology. They were born within six years of each other and did their major work between the 1890s and the 1910s. But I've chosen to start with the earlier figure of Tylor, typically seen as the founder of cultural anthropology, because his work provided a substrate for everyone theorizing about religion thereafter, helping to naturalize religion as an appropriate subject for an increasingly scientific age. Beyond that, Tylor, more than anyone, was the scholar who, from a resolutely nonreligious perspective, resituated religion as a product of human rationality. (In ways I'll discuss later, much contemporary work on religion by evolutionary and cognitive psychologists is essentially neo-Tylorian.)

Still, some readers will wonder why I've chosen these social theorists and not others. In truth, not a few sociologists these days chafe

against the notion that their discipline, with its universalizing ambitions, might be thought to be established in significant part by figures who seem so specific to a European intellectual milieu. Some will be disquieted by the fact that this work is still taught as foundational or that the field can still seem raptly in conversation with these scholars. Some would highlight, as more recent textbooks do, the remarkable work of Harriet Martineau, Charlotte Perkins Gilman, W. E. B. Du Bois (whose intellectual formation was the subject of a previous book of mine), or, indeed, Beatrice Potter Webb—a figure who loomed large in my own family lore, being my mother's great-aunt Bo. "I hope you slept well," my mother said to her one morning when, as a girl, she was staying with the Webbs in London. Aunt Bo glowered and set her straight: "I *never* sleep." Vital disciplines don't sleep either; they toss and turn. Some contemporary sociologists, accordingly, promote an engagement with more far-flung figures. Why not say that our subject is "social thought," and enlist as forerunners intellectuals from other parts of the world? A few, pledging to decolonize their field, talk of "Southern Theory," even at the risk of enshrining another tidy distinction between North and South.

In truth, disciplinary canons are always in the process of being reshaped. For Talcott Parsons, after all, Pareto and Marshall were as important to sociology as Durkheim and Weber were. In *Introduction to the Science of Sociology*, a mammoth 1921 compendium edited by the Chicago stalwarts Robert E. Park and Ernest W. Burgess, you'll find Durkheim and Simmel to be well represented (along with many names now little known), while Weber is scarcely mentioned. Even granting the particular intellectual matrix I sought to explore, my argument could surely have unfolded through other thinkers.

I focus on these four thinkers for a couple of reasons. First, they are, as I try to make plain, *representative*—they emerge from an expansive but historically specific intellectual seedbed. Second, their work was not only methodologically self-conscious but also disciplinarily *influential*. Tylor's magnum opus was a touchstone for almost any academic thinking about religion in this era. Durkheim, not least through his *L'Année sociologique*, entrenched certain paradigms and templates that helped shape British (and American) anthropology and sociology.

Simmel, taken up first by the Chicago School, helped fertilize interactionist perspectives, as well as later work in humanistic sociology. Today, any discussion of rationality is likely to bring up categories from Weber.

By way of analogy, one could no doubt adjust the philosophical canon so that Hume and Kant were no longer the familiar names for sets of positions and the spotlight fell, instead, on Christian Wolff, Adam Ferguson, F. W. J. Schelling, and J. F. Herbart. One certainly can, as I do in my classes on global ethics, bring in thinkers from continents around the world who represent intellectual traditions outside the traditional canon. But if we're interested in the history of a disciplinary conversation, we can't lightly set aside decisions of longstanding about whom we argue with and through.

I'll also take care to show these thinkers not as disciplinary godheads but as historical subjects, embodied and situated within—which is to say captive to—social, economic, intellectual, and personal contexts. I'll sometimes be going "off-road"—away from the stuff you find on a syllabus and into lesser-known writings—because I want to convey a developmental sense of how our principals came by the thoughts for which they are known. (I take responsibility for translations where no translator is noted.) My hope is to capture at least some sense of the voices they were contradicting, modifying, amplifying, extending. Their ideas did not arrive via some scholarly version of ensoulment. What the Germans call *Biografismus* is the fallacy of reducing the thought to the thinker; but we all exist in and through history, and a reciprocal fallacy is, as Franz Rosenzweig insisted, to deny any connection between the way we think and the lives we live.

One consequence of these shaping historical circumstances is seen in the fact that our principals are men—critics of patriarchy, in the main, but also, inevitably, participants in it. They had intellectually formidable women in their lives and weren't oblivious to the multiple barriers that did so much to keep women sidelined from the institutional forms of intellectual life. They would have supported reforms allowing women to compete on a more equitable basis, but the injustice wasn't, so to speak, top of mind for them. Not a great deal is known about Anna Fox, Tylor's wife of nearly six decades; nor about Louise Dreyfus, who was

Durkheim's, for three decades. But Gertrud Kinel, Simmel's wife for a little less than two, published her own philosophical writings under the pseudonym Marie-Luise Enckendorff, including a short book about religion that greatly impressed Weber. And Weber's wife, née Marianne Schnitger, had more of a public profile than he had for most of his career; she was Germany's leading feminist intellectual, published significant books about the social and legal status of women, and, though impeded from pursuing an academic career of her own, had written a doctoral thesis (on Fichte and Marx). To study society does not remove you from society.

The disciplinary pioneers I write about aren't the only ones shaped by the currents and the contingencies of history. You have been, too, and so have I. A quirk of biography no doubt explains why I wanted to write this book in the first place. Much of my life has been spent in and around religious traditions. I have feasted at Eid al-Fitr with my Muslim cousins, celebrated Seders at home with my in-laws, recited a Sanskrit mantra as I meditated alone, and attended a nuptial Mass conducted by a cardinal. In my childhood, I sang in an Anglican school choir in England, went to Sunday school back home in Ghana in an interdenominational church (dressed in my Sabbath finery), and murmured "Now I Lay Me Down to Sleep" in prayer each night before I retired. My weekly recitation of the Nicene Creed was quite sincere, even if I always had difficulty understanding how Christ could be of "one substance with the Father"; the words had some extra-semantic resonance. Like millions of people, I have experienced the inward peace that comes from meditation—the sense of oneness with everything that is spoken of in contemplative traditions from around the world; but I have felt that sense of communion, too, at the end of a long season of training, rowing with my fellow oarsmen in perfect concord on the Thames near Henley, when my body was working as hard as it ever has. Then, as in the daily meditations of my teenage years, I felt with the Blessed Julian of Norwich, who lived six centuries ago, that "all will be well and all will be well, and all manner of things will be well." As a child, I gained security from a gold cross that hung on a chain around my neck, which had been blessed by a spirit that spoke through the mediumship of a modest Scottish postman, who also reassured me by transmitting benevolent messages from my long-dead English grandfather.

And because much of my childhood was spent in Kumasi, in Ghana's Ashanti region, I followed my father in pouring libations to our ancestors, who were once as real to me as the God whose presence I felt when I prayed. We would offer spirituous beverage, in particular, to the founder of my father's lineage, the warrior Akroma-Ampim. *Nana Akroma-Ampim, bɛgye nsa nom*: Akroma-Ampim, our elder, come take this alcohol to drink. We would honor, too, our formidable great-grandmother Takyiwah, or her brother Yao Antony, for whom, like Akroma-Ampim, I was named. Mind you, my father was an elder in his Methodist church and considered himself a good Christian; but as a proud Asante man, he also shared the "traditional" beliefs of the world where he grew up. If he dreamed, it meant that his *sunsum*—a spirit of consciousness—was traveling the realm; when he died, he believed, something would leave his body and join the ancestors, to be given offerings on occasion. He joined in practices related to Nyame, the sky god, as well as to Asase Yaa, the earth goddess, and to other spirits of divers kinds. There were ritual practices and prayers, and professional priests and shrines of varying degrees of authority and various scopes of jurisdiction. (When he visited friends in, say, Sierra Leone, he expected that, just as the people were different there, so the gods would be: alternative technologies of the divine.) The same would have been true of his grandparents—of the Asante people in the mid-nineteenth century. But it would never have occurred to his ancestors to define themselves as belonging to a tradition compounded of ritual and belief.[51] Those things we now call "Asante religion" were a constituent of everyday life; there is no word in nineteenth-century Asante-Twi (as in most of the world's languages until recently) to translate our word "religion."[52]

In many developmental accounts of religion, "primitive" persons traffic in magic, while civilized ones participate in complex and ecclesiastical forms of worship. In early religion, the whole world is enchanted; in advanced ones, a sphere of sacred doings is carved off from the sphere of everyday reality. Lucien Lévy-Bruhl had seen a gulf between the primitive and the civilized *mentalité*, and, although scholars no longer talk this way, they often posit a crevasse between two forms of life that correspond to those he was concerned with. But

as a child, I moved between a world where witches had to be warded off and ancestors appeased and a world where Anglican priests led you through the sacraments and the Creed; I detected no crossing of an intellectual crevasse, no transfigured *mentalité*. Neither was it clear that these were even rivalrous systems, competing for the same tasks. For my English kinfolk, religion seemed mainly to be something you did on Sundays; for my Asante kinfolk, interactions with spiritual entities were fluidly part of everyday activities. These were, in each place, things people did together, but not necessarily for similar reasons. I saw—I lived—continuities and discontinuities that my peers mainly did not. I had questions.

I still do. Should one believe in "religion"? Are we too quick to talk about the social construction of things without a sense of how the social has been constructed? In the chapters ahead, we'll circle the conceptual ouroboros I pointed toward at the start: how religion gave definition to the social sciences that gave definition to religion.